RHYTHM AND BLOOMS

AN ORIGINAL SCREENPLAY BY KELLY R. TENNEY

FORMAT	Feature Film	**GENRE**	Drama / Music / Community	**TONE**	Warm, Culturally Specific, Emotionally Rich
BUYERS	OWN / BET+	**SETTING**	Atlanta, GA -- Auburn Avenue	**STATUS**	Yellow Master -- October 2026

LOGLINE

A jazz club owner has six weeks to resurrect her late father's cancelled festival and save Auburn Avenue's Blue Note Lounge from a developer's demolition plan -- but the only path through runs straight through an unlikely landscape architect, a neighborhood still learning to trust her, and a song she has never been able to finish.

THE STORY

ELLIE CRUZ (early 40s) has held the Blue Note Lounge together through grief, debt, and slow displacement for three years. When Meridian Development LLC files a safety objection that could revoke her operating license, Ellie does the only thing that feels like fighting: she announces the Rhythm and Blooms Festival on Auburn Avenue -- her father's cancelled dream -- with six weeks and almost no money.

MILES BRADFORD (40s), a precise landscape architect rebuilding from his own professional collapse, signs on to design the rooftop garden at the center of the festival. He comes for the project. He stays for something harder to name. Together they navigate a compliance review, a structural certification, a neighborhood with long memories, and the quiet revelation that some things are better finished than left perfectly unfinished.

When the rooftop is restricted three days before opening, Ellie makes the choice that defines her: the festival moves indoors, acoustic, no amplification -- because the Blue Note always was the point. The night ends in a neighborhood blackout. The song gets played anyway. The next morning, the Auburn Avenue Cultural Preservation Board grants a twelve-month extension.

THEMES

Inheritance and what we do with grief

Community as active choice, not passive memory

Finishing what love left unfinished

Partnership as the condition of restoration

Black excellence rooted in place, not aspiration

BUYER FIT

OWN: Black family, healing, community, love, warmth. Festival as the holiday engine. Ellie and Miles as a classic OWN romantic restoration arc.

BET+: Cultural specificity embedded in every institution -- the club, the block, the board hearing, the mural. Black excellence that earns its ending.

CAST SUGGESTIONS

Viola Davis / Angela Bassett

ELLIE CRUZ -- Early 40s, Lead

The emotional and physical anchor of the film. Ellie runs on stubbornness and jazz and has never stopped grieving her father out loud. Needs an actress who can carry a 110-minute arc from exhausted keeper to deliberate artist. Davis brings the interior damage. Bassett brings the unshakeable spine.

Idris Elba / Omari Hardwick

MILES BRADFORD -- Early 40s, Lead

A landscape architect whose precision is a coping mechanism. The role requires technical authority that softens under pressure -- someone the audience believes rebuilt himself through discipline and is just beginning to trust something more human. Elba carries the weight. Hardwick carries the quiet.

Mahershala Ali / David Oyelowo

VICTOR LANGSTON -- 50s, Supporting

A developer whose buyout offer is sincere, whose withdrawal is earned, and whose final nod must cost him something visible. The role must not be a villain. It must be a man making a different choice than he planned. Both actors can hold complexity without softening it.

Cicely Tyson type / Loretta Devine

MS. ODESSA -- 80s, Supporting

The neighborhood's living memory. Fewer maxims, more behavior. Her cane keeping four-beat time at the festival finale is the scene. Needs physical presence and the authority that comes from having actually survived everything the script only describes.

Wood Harris / Delroy Lindo

DEON TAYLOR -- 50s, Supporting

The bartender who has seen everything and says the plain truth when no one else will. Deon speaks in declarative sentences. His big scene is staying when Yara leaves. Quiet, direct, loyal.

Ego Nwodim / Dominique Fishback

YARA -- Late 20s, Supporting

Overworked, gifted, the youngest person in the room who is also somehow the most exhausted. The scene where she says "Thanks for telling us" before she leaves is her entire arc in seven words. Needs an actress who can make that generosity hurt.

Jay Ellis / Duluth Jackson

CAM BRADFORD -- 40s, Supporting

Miles's brother. Warm, grounded, the one who sees Miles clearly and loves him anyway. Cam's tribute speech at the festival is the scene that unlocks the crowd. Needs presence and ease.